

Birkbeck Student Ethics Form 2025/26

In order to submit your ethics application, you should complete the form given here.

Once you have completed your answers, **use the finish later function to save your responses** and share the link this generates with anyone who you wish to consult for advice on your application.

You should submit your link (alongside the information sheet, the consent form, any advertising and a copy of the relevant protocol, any other information required for your ethics approval) **for review and approval through the correct process for your School.**

Students and staff are strongly advised to check local arrangements in their Schools/programmes as there may be other processes to use which take precedence over instructions outlined here.

If you are a student, you should share this link with your supervisor in the first instance and they should complete the supervisor sign off and then tell you what the next steps are.

The application will be considered by the relevant Ethics Lead and School/Faculty/College ethics committee (as necessary) and any amendments discussed with you until the content is agreed and ethics approval given once the application is submitted. When you submit your application you should download a copy of your responses.

1. Title of study *

Session-based Music queue Reordering
System Using Skip Behaviour as Implicit
Feedback ~ Data Science MSc Project

2. Your name *

William McKenna

3. Are you a student? *

- ☒ yes
- ☐ no

4. please indicate your level of study *

- ☐ Undergraduate
- ☒ Masters
- ☐ MPhil/PhD

☐ Professional Doctorate

5. Faculty *

☐ Business and Law

☐ Humanities and Social Science

☒ Science

Science Schools

9. School

- ☒ Computer and Mathematical Sciences
- ☐ Natural Sciences
- ☐ Psychological Science

10. will you be using AI in your research?

- ☐ yes
- ☒ no

Initial ethics questions

19. Is your application routine or non routine? See our responsibilities and procedures for ethical review for definitions: <https://www.bbk.ac.uk/about-us/governance/research-integrity>

- ☒ routine
- ☐ non-routine

20. If routine, please justify this. If the project is routine because it poses minimal risk please explain why. Where the project is routine because it is equivalent in terms of risks and methods to a project which has received ethics approvals in the last 3-5 years, include the approval number and/or title of study of the approval on which this is based. *

The project is routine as it involves the collection and analysis of personal music streaming data, which does include any sensitive data. Participation is completely voluntary and volunteers will be well informed of what will happen to their data. Upon reception of the data each dataset will be combined to the main dataset and a random UUID will be generated by python. Source data will then be immediately deleted from local storage. Upon completion of the project all data relating to the project will be deleted.

22. Is your research externally funded? (Please note, if you are sponsored by your employer to study at Birkbeck you should answer yes to this question.) *

- ☐ yes
- ☒ no

26. Briefly (~200 words) describe the purpose and rationale of the research, make the objectives of the study clear *

This project investigates whether a session-aware recommender system, informed by both skip behaviour and audio features, can dynamically reorder a music queue to reduce skip likelihood in real time. Current streaming platforms model long-term preferences well but are ill-equipped to capture what a user wants within a specific listening session, where mood and context shift considerably. This project addresses that gap.

Multiple models will be applied to the dataset; Logistic Regression, Random Tree, Recurrent Neural Network and a session aware sequential recommender system (SASRec). The use of two loss functions (an adapted DRrL and a custom function derived to take into account position of the skip in the session and position of the skip in the song) will also be investigated on the two neural networks.

27. Are there human participants in your research? *

☒ yes

☐ no

People responsible for the study

28. Name and role of person responsible for the study. Note: If you are a student or research assistant/post doc, the person responsible for the study will be your supervisor or module leader. If you hold a personal fellowship you are responsible for the study. This and the next question are closely linked, this question asks who ultimately is responsible for ensuring that all data collection is undertaken correctly whereas the next question asks who is actually collecting the data. *

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29. Name and role of person(s) collecting data. *

William McKenna

30. Names of any co-applicant(s) and their specific role (e.g. Staff, Masters, PhD, PI/Col on grant etc). For team projects this may include undergraduate co-applicants. For grant funded research this may involve collaborators at other institutions. (This question simply wants to know who else is working on the project, there may be nobody else apart from your supervisor). *

n/a

31. Has the person carrying out the study had previous experience of all the procedures and methods used in the study? *

☒ yes

☐ no

33. Date of application? *

13/05/2026

34. And when is data collection due to start? (This needs to be at least 2 weeks from the submission date and may be longer.) This is a target not a deadline. *

27/05/2026

35. When is data collection expected to end? This is a target not a deadline. *

13/06/2026

36. Please list the email addresses of all applicants. Please note, ethics approvals can only be granted to people with .bbk.ac.uk email addresses and this email address must be used for all data collection and communication with participants. *

wmcken01@student.bbk.ac.uk

Research which raises ethical issues with human participants

49. Where will the data collection take place? Note: Please select as many of the options given here as relevant.

- ☐ in a lab
- ☐ on campus
- ☐ in a participants home in the UK
- ☐ in a participants home outside the UK
- ☐ in a public place in the UK
- ☐ in a public place outside the UK
- ☐ in a participants workplace in the UK
- ☐ in a participants workplace outside the UK
- ☒ virtually within the UK
- ☒ virtually with participants from outside the UK
- ☐ other

51. Please list all instruments, materials and techniques you will use and make sure they are attached with your application when you submit it. Note: These are in addition to the general information sheet about the study, the consent form, the protocol and any further necessary information such as a Data Management Plan or copies of recruitment advertising.

- ☐ questionnaires
- ☐ focus group schedule and questions/agenda
- ☐ interview questions
- ☐ specific information about particular techniques such as EEG
- ☒ other

52. If other, please specify.

53. Describe the details of the methods and procedures of the data collection, please provide FULL information. Note: Do not merely list the names of measures and/or their acronyms; summarize them briefly (e.g. Buss-Durkee Hostility Inventory: a standardized self-report measure of trait aggression). Include any information about any interventions, interview schedules, duration, order and frequency of assessments and so on. It should be clear exactly what would happen to participants.

All participants will download their own personal spotify data and then email it to the researcher upon reading the information handout and signing the consent form to the researcher's university email address. From there it will be downloaded onto the researchers password protected device where it will be combined with the main dataset and assigned a random UUID. The source data will then be deleted from local storage.

54. Who will the participants be? Describe (a) the groups of participants that will be recruited; (b) the main inclusion and exclusion criteria; (c) make clear how many participants you plan to recruit into the study in total and (d) the expected age range of your participants (e.g. 5-7; 18-65, 65+ etc.).

- a) Colleagues, Friends, Family, Acquaintances, friends of friends of the researcher
- b) Exclusion of anyone under the age of 18
- c) 40 -60
- d) 19 - 65

55. Describe the recruitment procedures for the study. Give details of how potential participants will be identified and/or recruited. Describe any screening and selection procedures (e.g. collecting SES information) and explain why they are necessary. Note: Include all advertising materials (posters, draft emails, letters etc.) you intend to use as appendices to you application and refer to them here as appropriate.

A message/email sent out to contacts [1]

A possible instagram story reaching out for volunteers [2]

56. Are there any potential conflicts of interest with your participants? A conflict of interest is a situation where personal or professional factors could affect - or could be reasonably assumed by an external party to have affected - your judgement in your research. In some situations a conflict of interest is unavoidable. Note: For research to be ethical potential conflicts of interest are declared. For students conducting research in their own organisations please also consider whether conducting your research (e.g. acquiring specific knowledge from co-workers) will adversely affect you in the future in a work capacity.

no

57. Do you anticipate that you will recruit Birkbeck staff and/or students (or people closely related to Birkbeck staff and students) in your data collection? Note: For research to be ethical potential conflicts of interest are declared. Collecting data from close friends or colleagues is always a conflict of interest which is why this question is included.

☐ yes

☒ no

59. Are there potential risks of adverse effects on the researcher who is collecting the data resulting from conducting the research?

☐ yes

☒ no

64. Describe any potential risks to or adverse effects on the participants resulting from participation and what measures have been taken to address them? Note: Describe any discomfort or inconvenience that participants may experience. Include information about procedures that for some people could be physically stressful or might impinge on the safety of participants, e.g. noise levels, visual stimuli, equipment; or that for some people could be psychologically stressful or distressing, e.g. mood induction procedure, questions about sensitive or painful personal experiences.

65. Is there a possibility of a participant disclosing (or the researcher identifying) any issues of concern (e.g. legal, emotional, psychological health)?

☐ yes

☒ no

Please note: if taught students want to carry out research about whistleblowing, and/or discrimination, bullying, or harassment with people who have protected characteristics under the Equalities Act (2010) in relation to a person or organisation that has a duty of care under the Equalities Act then advice should be sought from the Faculty Ethics Committee. The protected characteristics are age, disability, gender reassignment, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex, and sexual orientation. More information can be found about the equalities act here [Equality and diversity law — Birkbeck, University of London \(bbk.ac.uk\)](https://www.bbk.ac.uk/equality-and-diversity-law).

67. Describe the procedures to obtain informed consent. Describe when and how consent will be obtained. Give details of who will take consent and how it will be done. If you plan to seek informed consent from vulnerable groups (e.g. people with mental or physical health problems or learning difficulties, victims of crime, individuals in any form of custody or detention, those aged under 18), say how you will ensure that consent is voluntary and fully informed.

A consent form will be sent to each participant upon agreement of taking part in the project. Alongside an information sheet which will outline what their data will be used for, how it will be stored, how long it will be stored for and how it will be used. It will also be made clear to the participants that should at any point they would like to withdraw from the process all data will be immediately deleted.

68. Will consent be written?

☒ yes

☐ no

69. If yes, will this be based on your Schools template consent form? (You will be required to provide a copy of the form.)

☐ yes

☒ no

72. In terms of what participants are told about the study, will you provide a written information sheet? If yes, you will need to provide a copy to the reviewer.

☒ yes

☐ no

74. Will any information on procedures or the purpose of the study be withheld?

☐ yes

☒ no

76. Will participants receive payments, expenses or other benefits and inducements?

☒ yes

☐ no

77. If yes, give details. If it is monetary, say how much, how it will be paid and on what basis is the amount determined.

On the participant's request, an analysis will be carried out on their historical data to provide them a personalised summary of their listening habits.

78. At the end of the study, what will participants be told about the investigation? Give details of debriefings, ways of alleviating distress that might be caused by the study etc. Note: If a de-brief document will be provided you need to provide a copy.

Participants will be issued with a copy of the dissertation that will contain all results of the research

79. Describe what you have done to ascertain that you are not collecting more personal data than you need or data which is not pertinent to your research questions. Personal data (also known as personally identifying data) is data which makes an individual identifiable either on its own or in combination with other data.

After collection of the data if requested a short analysis will be provided of the personalised listening habits after this has been carried out, as soon as this has been released to the participant

all personal identifiers will be removed upon combination with the main dataset as a random UUID will be assigned using python

Note: Ethical research is rigorous and well thought through. You understand why you are asking the specific questions to participants and how these questions will help to answer your research questions whether this is a single study or part of a longitudinal data set. You have thought through how to minimize the personal data you collect – for example you may not need an individual to give their name at the start of an interview for the data from that interview to still be relevant and you do not impose on your participants by asking them questions which are unlikely to be used in your final analysis.

Data protection regulation questions

80. Please briefly describe the nature of the personal data you will be collecting and why you need to collect this data. Personal data is data which can make an individual identifiable or which when used in combination with other data can make an individual identifiable.

Personal data will only be collected at the request of the participant in order to provide a personalised listening summary prior to the actual research. After this all personal data will be removed

Note: GDPR defines personal data as any information relating to an identifiable person who can be identified, directly or indirectly, by reference to (for example) a name, an identification number, location data, an online identifier or to one or more factors specific to the physical, physiological, genetic, mental, economic, cultural or social identity of that natural person". Personal data can thus include someone's name, their email address, their IP address, their name on their social media accounts etc. In addition, if different identifiers are put together to make someone identifiable when each identifier on its own protects their identity this also constitutes personal data.

81. How many participants will you be collecting personal data from? Note: You should always look to minimize the amount of personally identifying data you need to collect, whilst being mindful that your research needs to retain its rigour.

40-60

82. Are you recording personal data other than on the consent form (such as recording an individuals name at the start of an interview recording)?

☐ yes

☒ no

84. Describe the procedures in place for making sure that the participant personal data collected will be treated with confidentiality and their anonymity respected across all sources including consent forms, recordings and transcripts prior to anonymisation. Please list all people who will have access to the data.

After the requested personal listening summary has been provided to the participant all personal data will be deleted and a random UUID assigned to each dataset using python.

This description should include how you will protect your participants identity as you collect the data, as you analyse the data, and in anything you produce from the data such as a thesis, paper or other report for a third party. It should also consider how, and up to what stage, a participant may withdraw their data from the analysis. Please note, sharing raw data (i.e. data which has not been effectively anonymised) with an external organisation is not permitted unless a suitable data sharing agreement is in place and the necessary consents have been obtained from participants.

85. How are you ensuring that personal data will be kept separate from research data? (For example, hard copy consent forms only held in a locked filing cabinet with research data on a password protected hard drive.) Note: please consider indirect identifiers here as well.

Will be deleted

86. Will you be using any software (e.g. Qualtrics, Nvivo) in processing your personal data or your anonymised data? If so, please name the software.

Python

Please be aware, if you intend to use an AI transcription service you need explicit consent from participants to upload their data to an AI dataset.

87. Will any third parties (e.g. a transcription service, an external collaborator) be involved in processing the data prior to anonymisation?

☐ yes

☒ no

89. How long will personal data be kept and why has this time period been selected? (Until the end of the study or for students' assessment, for a defined period, in perpetuity etc.)

dependent on whether the participant would like a personalised listening history in return for providing their data, if yes as soon as this summary has been sent to the participant, if no, as soon as it has been combined with the main dataset and assigned a random UUID by python

90. Will you be uploading your anonymised data to an online repository? Please note:

Taught students should only upload their anonymised data to a repository if they are publishing a research output from the data.

PGR students and staff are required to share their research data where possible as per Birkbeck's Open Research Policy– see Section 4 - <https://www.bbk.ac.uk/about-us/policies/open-access-research>

☐ yes

☒ no

92. Are you collecting any special category data? (Personal data revealing racial or ethnic origin, personal data revealing political opinions, personal data revealing religious or philosophical beliefs, personal data revealing trade union membership, genetic data, biometric data (where used for identification purposes), data concerning health, data concerning a person's sex life, data concerning a person's sexual orientation, criminal offence data.)

☐ yes

☒ no

A Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) is a process to help you identify and minimise the data protection risks of a project. You must do a DPIA for processing that is likely to result in a high risk to individuals or for any other major project which requires the processing of personal data. For projects where the risk is lower, a data management plan should be sufficient, and for projects which have a low or very low risk of severe impact on individuals the information provided in the ethics application should be sufficient. To assess the level of risk, you must consider both the likelihood and the severity of any impact on individuals and the number of individuals you will be collecting data from. High risk could result from either a high probability of some harm, or a lower possibility of serious harm. The following questions are designed to help you determine whether you need an additional DMP or DPIA for this work.

100. Are you collecting any of the following types of data or, based on the design of your research, do you think it is extremely likely you will attract participants from these groups? Please note, if using random sampling techniques then you are NOT targeting these groups specifically so you do not need to select any.

☐ special category data

- ☐ children under 13
- ☐ participants with declared disabilities and/or study support plans
- ☐ members of the forced migrant community
- ☐ people with mental health conditions
- ☐ people who may have increased vulnerabilities due to their age
- ☐ data where, if it fell into the wrong hands there could be Risk of physical harm, Risks to their rights and freedoms, Negative impacts on their daily lives or privacy or other negative social consequences
- ☐ artificial intelligence, machine learning and deep learning, smart technologies (including wearables), 'internet of things' applications
- ☒ not applicable

You need an additional DMP in order to collect data from these categories - contact the research data support manager for advice. AI is a rapidly developing field so whilst ethics applications should be sufficient advice should be sought as appropriate

101. If you are collecting data of this type, is your dataset.

- ☐ small - up to approximately 25 people
- ☐ medium - up to 100 people
- ☐ large - up to 500 people
- ☐ very large - over 500 people

Based on your answer to the previous question, you may need an additional DMP in order to collect this data. Contact the research data support manager for advice.

Health and safety regulations and risk assessments questions

104. Are any risk assesments required for this research?

☐ yes

☒ no

105. If no, please justify this.

The data contains only personal music streaming history so does therefore not contain any sensitive data has any risk

Sign off page

106. Researchers: Please note any areas you would like the ethics team to specifically consider. Supervisors (for applications from students): as the supervisor, please provide a statement confirming that you have read this application and are happy for it to be submitted for ethics approval. please note any areas you would like the ethics team to specifically consider.

No area in particular

107. Please confirm which documents are shared with the reviewer to support this application. Tick all that apply.

- ☒ Information sheet
- ☒ Consent
- ☐ Debrief
- ☐ Recruitment material
- ☐ Research material (scales, interview questions etc)
- ☐ DMP and/or DPIA
- ☐ Risk assessment
- ☐ Other

You should click finish later until you are ready to submit the form and share the link this generates with anyone who needs to review at this point - if a student this will be your supervisor, or else follow your local faculty process. Submit the link plus all associated documentation as instructed by your School or Faculty.

Ethics approval is only granted once the form is approved by your local processes (including any necessary changes from the review process) and submitted on the system.

109. As supervisor, i am happy to sign this research as:

- ☒ routine
- ☐ sensitive (refer to Faculty Ethics Committee
- ☐ extremely sensitive (refer to Faculty and then College Ethics Committees)

110. Comments (please add any information that you would like to be considered as part of this application)

0/32,000 characters

111. Signature (type name)

Cen Wan